

PROJECT Get found on Google: the local SEO checklist	DRAWN BY Caleb Bolden · calebbolden.com	SHEET checklist 02	REV A
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The one-time fixes, then the weekly routine that does the compounding.

When someone searches "plumber near me" or "best salon in your town," Google decides who shows up in the map pack. In the 2026 Whitespark Local Search Ranking Factors survey, Google Business Profile signals carry about 32% of map-pack ranking weight, on-page website signals about 19%, and review signals continue to climb. That tells you exactly where your effort goes: profile first, website second, reviews forever. Written for owners, not marketers.

A One-time fixes

A weekend, once.

- 01 ☐ **Claim your Google Business Profile and fill in every field.** No blanks. Complete profiles get dramatically more clicks than partial ones, and this single listing outweighs everything else on this page.
- 02 ☐ **Choose the most specific primary category that fits.** "HVAC contractor," not "contractor." Category choice is repeatedly measured as one of the biggest single ranking levers. Add accurate secondary categories after.
- 03 ☐ **Make your business name, address, and phone number identical everywhere.** Website, Google, Yelp, Facebook, directories. Same suite number, same phone format. Inconsistent listings quietly drag down local visibility.
- 04 ☐ **Hunt down old listings with a previous address or number and fix or remove them.** Search your business name plus your old address to find them.
- 05 ☐ **Upload 10 to 15 real photos to your profile now.** Storefront, team, work in progress, finished jobs. Businesses with photos get 42% more direction requests and 35% more website clicks (Google's own data).
- 06 ☐ **Enter your services individually in the services section with descriptions.** Not just a sentence in your business description.
- 07 ☐ **Set accurate hours, including holidays.** Wrong hours are one of the fastest ways to turn a ready buyer into a competitor's customer.
- 08 ☐ **Give each core service and each town you serve its own page on your website.** On-page signals are the second-largest ranking factor, and one generic homepage cannot rank for ten services in five towns.
- 09 ☐ **Put your city and service in your page titles and headings, written naturally.** "Water heater repair in Bentonville" as a heading beats "Our Services."
- 10 ☐ **Put your full address, service area, and an embedded Google map on your contact page.**

- 11 ☐ **Get listed in the directories that matter for your industry.** Chamber of commerce, BBB, and your trade's directories, with the identical name-address-phone from item 3.
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B The weekly routine

1 to 2 hours, forever. This is the part that compounds.

- 12 ☐ **Ask every happy customer for a Google review, the same day.** Recency now matters more than raw count in ranking studies: a steady weekly trickle beats an occasional burst. Make the ask part of closing the job.
- 13 ☐ **Respond to every review within a day or two, positive and negative.** 88% of consumers prefer businesses that respond to all reviews, and high responders measurably outrank low responders (BrightLocal 2025; Whitespark 2026).
- 14 ☐ **Never buy, trade for, or fake reviews.** Three quarters of consumers actively watch for fakes, and Google removes profiles for it. Not worth it in any universe.
- 15 ☐ **Post to your profile once or twice a week.** An offer, a finished job with photo, a seasonal tip. Each post takes under 10 minutes, and profiles that look alive get rewarded as engagement signals keep climbing.
- 16 ☐ **Add a couple of fresh photos each month.**
- 17 ☐ **Turn on messaging and answer the Q&A section.** Questions sitting unanswered on your profile are being answered by strangers instead.
- 18 ☐ **Add one genuinely useful page or update to your website monthly.** A common question answered properly, a project write-up, a seasonal checklist for customers.
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C Keep score

Monthly, 10 minutes.

- 19 ☐ **Check your profile's calls, direction requests, and website clicks in the performance tab.** These are the numbers your weekly routine should move. Write them down monthly.
- 20 ☐ **Review your profile quarterly for changes you didn't make.** Google auto-applies suggested edits (hours, categories) from the public, and they can silently overwrite you.

What to expect

Local SEO compounds, it does not spike. The typical pattern: months 1 to 3 are groundwork with little visible movement, months 3 to 6 show map-pack gains, and months 6 to 12 are where the phone measurably rings more. Low-competition markets move faster, sometimes inside 60 days. If someone promises page one in two weeks, keep your wallet in your pocket.

Stuck, or short on hours?

The one-time fixes above are the exact first mile of my SEO engagements. If you would rather have it done for you, or want your setup audited before you invest a year of weekly effort, tell me where you are stuck.

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Caleb Bolden does SEO, websites, and AI consulting for local small businesses. Sources: Whitespark Local Search Ranking Factors 2026, BrightLocal Local Consumer Review Survey 2025, and Google Business Profile documentation.